

Document number: P0631R5

Date: 2019-01-12

Project: Programming Language C++

Audience: Library Working Group

Authors: Lev Minkovsky, John McFarlane

Reply-to: Lev Minkovsky lminkovsky@outlook.com; John McFarlane john@mcfarlane.name

Math Constants

0. Abstract

There is a consensus in a C++ standardization community that it would be beneficial to add to the standard library definitions for the most commonly used mathematical constants. Chapters 2 and 3 introduce the problem and describe prior standardization efforts. The core proposal is in chapter 4, where the abovementioned questions are discussed and answered. The chapter 5 presents decisions made in chapter 4 as a list of modifications to the standard document.

1. Changelog

Changes from R4:

- Audience changed to LWG
- Abstract reworded to reflect the decisions made by LEWG in San Diego.
- Math constants placed into a new nested namespace `std::math`.
- Subchapters 4.3 “Definitions” and 4.4. “A “Hello world” program for math constants” removed.
- In chapter 5,
 - new `FloatingPoint` concept introduced,
 - new `[math.constants]` subclause introduced,
 - primary variable templates are ill-formed; implementation specializes them for floating point types,
 - ¹*Requires* removed,
 - ¹ *Remarks* addresses `[namespace.std]/3` by explicitly allowing program template specializations.
- Chapter 6 “Design Alternatives” removed.

Changes from R3:

- Several wording changes
- The math constants are moved into a new proposed header `<math>`
- A spelling error in `m_denominator` is corrected
- Variable templates now end with `_v`
- The section 6 added on design decisions to be voted on by LEWG. The abstract is updated accordingly.

- Acknowledgements updated

Changes from R2:

- The variable templates are now named without an underscore
- All definitions are done inside `std` instead of nested namespaces
- New constructor added to the `floating_t` class
- An example added of how to create an instance of the `floating_t` class with higher than double precision
- A possible implementation of `std::piv` is suggested
- Abstract added
- Chapter 5 is merged as a sub-chapter into chapter 4.

Changes from R1:

- Several typos fixed
- A better URL for Boost math constant
- Design goal 4) is replaced
- Radian, Catalan's, Apéry's and Glaisher's constants are no longer proposed
- Motivation behind Euler-Mascheroni and golden ratio constants added
- The inverse constants now have underscores in their names
- A link to the list of Wolfram constants removed as no longer relevant

Changes from R0:

- Added changelog, header and footer
- Several readability improvements
- Chapters are numbered
- The 4th and 6th chapters subdivided into subchapters
- Design goals stated
- A different set of constants proposed
- Naming conventions are now different
- A drop-in replacement for POSIX constants no longer proposed
- All definitions are in the new `math_constants` namespace
- Variable template types are inline
- Added new implementation requirements
- *float* and *double* typed constants proposed
- Boost constants described in the chapter 3.
- The 5th and 6th chapters reworked according to the abovementioned changes
- Links to the lists of Wolfram and Boosts constants added to the 7th chapter
- The types of constants should be directly or indirectly `constexpr` constructible from a floating-point type.
- Examples added of user-defined types suitable for instantiation of math constants

2. Introduction

C++ inherited from C a rich library of mathematical functions which continues to grow with every release. Amid all this abundance, there is a strange gap: none of the major mathematical constants is defined in the standard. This proposal is aimed to rectify this omission.

3. Motivation

Mathematical constants such as π and e frequently appear in mathematical algorithms. A software engineer can easily define them, but from their perspective, this is akin to making a reservation at a restaurant and being asked to bring their own salt. The C++ implementers appreciate this need and attempt to fulfil it with non-standard extensions.

The IEEE Standard 1003.1™-2008 a.k.a POSIX.1-2008 stipulates that on all systems supporting the X/Open System Interface Extension, “the <math.h> header shall define the following symbolic constants. The values shall have type *double* and shall be accurate to at least the precision of the *double* type.”

<code>M_E</code>	- value of e
<code>M_LOG2E</code>	- value of $\log_2 e$
<code>M_LOG10E</code>	- value of $\log_{10} e$
<code>M_LN2</code>	- value of $\ln 2$
<code>M_LN10</code>	- value of $\ln 10$
<code>M_PI</code>	- value of π
<code>M_PI_2</code>	- value of $\frac{\pi}{2}$
<code>M_PI_4</code>	- value of $\frac{\pi}{4}$
<code>M_1_PI</code>	- value of $\frac{1}{\pi}$
<code>M_2_PI</code>	- value of $\frac{2}{\pi}$
<code>M_2_SQRTPI</code>	- value of $\frac{2}{\sqrt{\pi}}$
<code>M_SQRT2</code>	- value of $\sqrt{2}$
<code>M_SQRT1_2</code>	- value of $\frac{\sqrt{2}}{2}$

POSIX.1-2008 explicitly states that these constants are outside of the ISO C standard and should be hidden behind an appropriate feature test macro. On some POSIX-compliant systems, this macro is defined as `_USE_MATH_DEFINES`, which led to a common assumption that defining this macro prior to the inclusion of `math.h` makes these constants accessible. In reality, this is true only in the following scenario:

- 1) The implementation defines these constants, and
- 2) It uses `_USE_MATH_DEFINES` as a feature test macro, and
- 3) This macro is defined prior to the first inclusion of `math.h` or any header file that directly or indirectly includes `math.h`.

These makes the availability of these constants extremely fragile when the code base is ported from one implementation to another or to a newer version of the same implementation. In fact, something as benign as including a new header file may cause them to disappear.

The OpenCL standard by the Kronos Group offers the same set of preprocessor macros in three variants: with a suffix `_H`, with a suffix `_F` and without a suffix, to be used in fp16, fp32 and fp64 calculations

respectively. The first and the last sets are macro-protected. It also defines in the `cl` namespace the following variable templates:

```
e_v, log2e_v, log10e_v, ln2_v, ln10_v, pi_v, pi_2_v, pi_4_v, one_pi_v, two_pi_v, two_sqrtpi_v, sqrt2_v,
sqrt1_2_v
```

as well as their instantiations based on a variety of floating-point types and abovementioned macros. An OpenCL developer can therefore utilize a value of `cl::pi_v<float>`; they can also access `cl::pi_v<double>`, but only if the `cl_khr_fp64` macro is defined.

The GNU C++ library offers an alternative approach. It includes an implementation-specific file `ext\cmath` that defines in the `__gnu_cxx` namespace the templated definitions of the following constants:

```
__pi, __pi_half, __pi_third, __pi_quarter, __root_pi_div_2, __one_div_pi, __two_div_pi, __two_div_root_pi,
__e, __one_div_e, __log2_e, __log10_e, __ln_2, __ln_3, __ln_10, __gamma_e, __phi, __root_2,
__root_3, __root_5, __root_7, __one_div_root_2
```

The access to these constants is quite awkward. For example, to use a *double* value of π , a programmer would have to write `__gnu_cxx::__math_constants::__pi<double>`.

The Boost library has its own extensive set of constants, comprised of the following subsets:

- rational fractions (including $\frac{1}{2}$)
- functions of 2 and 10
- functions of π , e , ϕ (golden ratio) and Euler-Mascheroni γ constant
- trigonometric constants
- values of Riemann ζ (zeta) function
- statistical constants (various values of skewness and kurtosis)
- Catalan's, Glaisher's and Khinchin's constants

Components of their names are subdivided by an underscore, for example: `one_div_root_pi`. Boost provides their definitions for floating-point types in the following namespaces:

```
boost::math::constants::float_constants
boost::math::constants::double_constants
boost::math::constants::long_double_constants
```

For user-defined types, Boost constants are accessed through a function call, for example:

```
boost::math::constants::pi<MyFPTType>();
```

All these efforts, although helpful, clearly indicate the need for standard C++ to provide a set of math constants that would be both easy to use and appropriately accurate.

4. Design considerations and proposed definitions

4.0. Design goals.

- 1) The user should be able to easily replace all POSIX constants with standard C++ constants.

- 2) The constants should be available for all floating-point types without type conversion and with maximum precision of their respective types.
- 3) It should be possible to easily create a set of values of basic trigonometric functions of common angles, also with their maximum precision.
- 4) The constants should provide tangible benefits for C++ users interested in numerical analysis.
- 5) It should be possible to instantiate them for user defined types.

4.1. The set of constants and their names

To achieve the design goals 1), 3) and 4) we need to provide the following three groups of constants:

Group 1:

e - value of e
 log2e - value of $\log_2 e$
 log10e - value of $\log_{10} e$
 ln2 - value of $\ln 2$
 ln10 - value of $\ln 10$
 pi - value of π
 inv_pi - value of $\frac{1}{\pi}$
 inv_sqrtpi - value of $\frac{1}{\sqrt{\pi}}$
 sqrt2 - value of $\sqrt{2}$

Group 2:

sqrt3 - value of $\sqrt{3}$
 inv_sqrt3 - value of $\frac{1}{\sqrt{3}}$

Group 3:

egamma - value of Euler-Mascheroni γ constant
 phi - value of golden ratio constant $\phi = (1+\sqrt{5})/2$

The group 1 constants will help us to achieve the design goals 1) and 4), while the group 2 will do the same for the goals 2) and 4). Although the members of group 3 are used less frequently, they are still helpful for the design goal 4). For example, the Euler-Mascheroni constant γ appears in the formula for a Bessel function of a second kind of order ν (source:

www.mhtlab.uwaterloo.ca/courses/me755/web_chap4.pdf):

$$Y_\nu(x) = \frac{2}{\pi} J_\nu(x) \left(\ln \frac{x}{2} + \gamma \right) - \frac{1}{\pi} \sum_{k=0}^{\nu-1} \frac{(\nu - k - 1)!}{k!} \left(\frac{x}{2} \right)^{2k-\nu} +$$

$$+ \frac{1}{\pi} \sum_{k=0}^{\infty} \frac{(-1)^{k-1} \left[\left(1 + \frac{1}{2} + \cdots + \frac{1}{k} \right) + \left(1 + \frac{1}{2} + \cdots + \frac{1}{k+\nu} \right) \right]}{k!(k+\nu)!} \left(\frac{x}{2} \right)^{2k+\nu}$$

With the addition of the Euler-Mascheroni constant, it will become possible to numerically calculate the value of γ using only the constants presented in this proposal and the C++ 17 standard functions. As to the golden ratio ϕ , besides its traditional design applications, it is also used in the golden-section search, a method of finding a function extremum, see https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Golden-section_search.

It should be noted that all floating-point types are stored internally as a combination of a sign bit, a binary exponent and a binary normalized significand. If a ratio of two floating-point numbers of the same type is an exact power of 2 (within a certain limit), their significands will be identical. Therefore, in order to achieve the design goal 1), we don't have to provide replacements for both `M_PI` and `M_PI_2` and `M_PI_4`. The user will be able to divide the `M_PI` replacement by 2 and by 4 and achieve the goals 2) and 3).

4.2. Where to place the definitions?

None of the existing C++ headers would be ideal to define math constants. The `<cmath>` header is meant for functionality that is either already in the C standard or could be introduced there at a later date. The proposed definitions however are based on variable templates and therefore are not C compatible. The header `<numeric>`, like the rest of the C++ algorithm library, is dedicated to operations on containers and other sequences (see 23.1.1); math constants would not be a good fit there either. The new `<math>` header would give us flexibility to add mathematical functionality regardless of the dynamics of C standardization.

If we are to place math constants directly into `std`, this could lead to potential name collisions. For example, the following code fragment:

```
using namespace std;
constexpr double e = 2.71828;
constexpr double esqr = e*e;
```

will cease to be well-formed if preceded by `#include <math>`. We therefore suggest to introduce a new nested namespace `std::math` that will contain math constants and potentially other future numeric APIs.

4.3. Access patterns

Because the standard won't provide a drop-in replacement for POSIX/OpenCL/GNU constants, it will be up to the user how, or even whether, to transition to standardized constants. Some motivated users may do this via a global search-and-replace. It is likely however that many C++ projects will have the standard constants introduced alongside with the extant POSIX or user-defined constants. This may cause readability problems as well as subtle computational issues. For example, let's consider the following code fragment:

```
#define _USE_MATH_DEFINES
#include "math.h"

template<typename T> constexpr T pi =3.14159265358979323846L;

constexpr long double MY_OLD_PI = M_PI; //has been here for 10+ years
constexpr long double MY_NEW_PI = pi<long double>;

static_assert(MY_OLD_PI == MY_NEW_PI, "OMG!");
```

It compiles on Windows, where *long double* is 64-bit, but fails on Linux, where it is 128-bit. The users that need to support 128-bit *long double* will have to carefully assess the risk of having slightly different values of math constants in the same project.

If an existing codebase already has user-defined math constants, their definitions can easily be updated with standard constants, for example:

```
const double PI = std::math::pi;
```

In a more “greenfield” situation, where math constants are just being introduced, they can be imported into a global scope by the `using` directive, for example:

```
using std::math::pi;
```

If the user decides that in their particular domain, math constants should always have a specific type, they are welcome to redefine them based upon the appropriate standard constants. For example, the following definition will entail that `pi` is thought to be `float`:

```
constexpr float pi = std::math::pif;
```

5. Proposed changes in the standard

5.1. “Header <concepts> synopsis” [concepts.syn]

After

```
// 17.4.14, concept CopyConstructible
template<class T> concept CopyConstructible = see below ;
```

the following needs to be inserted:

```
// 17.4.15, concept FloatingPoint
template<class T> concept FloatingPoint = see below ;
```

5.2. “Language-related concepts” [concepts.lang]

The following needs to be appended:

17.4.15 FloatingPoint concept [concept.floatingp]

```
template<class T>
    concept FloatingPoint = is_floating_point_v<T>;
```

5.3. “General” [numerics.general]

² should be updated as follows:

² The following subclauses describe components for complex number types, random number generation, numeric (*n*-at-a-time) arrays, generalized numeric algorithms and mathematical constants and functions for floating-point types, as summarized in Table 81.

In the table 81, a new subclause should be added:

[math.constants]	Mathematical constants	<math>
----------------------------------	------------------------	--------

5.4. New subclause [math.constants]

After [c.math] “Mathematical functions for floating point types”, a new subclause [math.constants] should be added as follows:

[math.constants] Mathematical constants [math.constants]

[math.syn] Header <math> synopsis [math.syn]

```
#include <type_traits>
```

```
namespace math {
```

```
template<typename T> inline constexpr T e_v           = unspecified
template<typename T> inline constexpr T log2e_v      = unspecified
template<typename T> inline constexpr T log10e_v     = unspecified
template<typename T> inline constexpr T pi_v         = unspecified
template<typename T> inline constexpr T inv_pi_v     = unspecified
template<typename T> inline constexpr T inv_sqrtpi_v = unspecified
template<typename T> inline constexpr T ln2_v        = unspecified
template<typename T> inline constexpr T ln10_v       = unspecified
template<typename T> inline constexpr T sqrt2_v      = unspecified
template<typename T> inline constexpr T sqrt3_v      = unspecified
template<typename T> inline constexpr T inv_sqrt3_v  = unspecified
template<typename T> inline constexpr T egamma_v     = unspecified
template<typename T> inline constexpr T phi_v        = unspecified
```

```
template<FloatingPoint T> inline constexpr e_v<T>      = see below
template<FloatingPoint T> inline constexpr log2e_v<T>  = see below
template<FloatingPoint T> inline constexpr log10e_v<T> = see below
template<FloatingPoint T> inline constexpr pi_v<T>     = see below
template<FloatingPoint T> inline constexpr inv_pi_v<T>  = see below
template<FloatingPoint T> inline constexpr inv_sqrtpi_v<T> = see below
template<FloatingPoint T> inline constexpr ln2_v<T>    = see below
template<FloatingPoint T> inline constexpr ln10_v<T>   = see below
template<FloatingPoint T> inline constexpr sqrt2_v<T>  = see below
template<FloatingPoint T> inline constexpr sqrt3_v<T>  = see below
template<FloatingPoint T> inline constexpr inv_sqrt3_v<T> = see below
template<FloatingPoint T> inline constexpr egamma_v<T> = see below
template<FloatingPoint T> inline constexpr phi_v<T>    = see below
```

```
inline constexpr float ef = e_v<float>;
inline constexpr float log2ef = log2e_v<float>;
inline constexpr float log10ef = log10e_v<float>;
```



```

inline constexpr float pif = pi_v<float>;
inline constexpr float inv_pif = inv_pi_v<float>;
inline constexpr float inv_sqrtpif = inv_sqrtpi_v<float>;
inline constexpr float ln2f = ln2_v<float>;
inline constexpr float ln10f = ln10_v<float>;
inline constexpr float sqrt2f = sqrt2_v<float>;
inline constexpr float sqrt3f = sqrt3_v<float>;
inline constexpr float inv_sqrt3f = inv_sqrt3_v<float>;
inline constexpr float egammaf = egamma_v<float>;
inline constexpr float phif = phi_v<float>;

inline constexpr double e = e_v<double>;
inline constexpr double log2e = log2e_v<double>;
inline constexpr double log10e = log10e_v<double>;
inline constexpr double pi = pi_v<double>;
inline constexpr double inv_pi = inv_pi_v<double>;
inline constexpr double inv_sqrtpi = inv_sqrtpi_v<double>;
inline constexpr double ln2 = ln2_v<double>;
inline constexpr double ln10 = ln10_v<double>;
inline constexpr double sqrt2 = sqrt2_v<double>;
inline constexpr double sqrt3 = sqrt3_v<double>;
inline constexpr double inv_sqrt3 = inv_sqrt3_v<double>;
inline constexpr double egamma = egamma_v<double>;
inline constexpr double phi = phi_v<double>;

inline constexpr long double el = e_v<long double>;
inline constexpr long double log2el = log2e_v<long double>;
inline constexpr long double log10el = log10e_v<long double>;
inline constexpr long double pil = pi_v<long double>;
inline constexpr long double inv_pil = inv_pi_v<long double>;
inline constexpr long double inv_sqrtpil = inv_sqrtpi_v<long double>;
inline constexpr long double ln2l = ln2_v<long double>;
inline constexpr long double ln10l = ln10_v<long double>;
inline constexpr long double sqrt2l = sqrt2_v<long double>;
inline constexpr long double sqrt3l = sqrt3_v<long double>;
inline constexpr long double inv_sqrt3l = inv_sqrt3_v<long double>;
inline constexpr long double egammal = egamma_v<long double>;
inline constexpr long double phil = phi_v<long double>;

}

```

¹ *Remarks:* These variable templates are initialized with implementation-defined values of e , $\log_2 e$, $\log_{10} e$, π , $\frac{1}{\pi}$, $\frac{1}{\sqrt{\pi}}$, $\ln 2$, $\ln 10$, $\sqrt{2}$, $\sqrt{3}$, $\frac{1}{\sqrt{3}}$, Euler-Mascheroni γ constant and golden ratio ϕ constant ($\frac{1+\sqrt{5}}{2}$), respectively. For each floating-point type, an instantiation of every variable template is equal to the closest representable value of the respective mathematical constant. The instantiation of variable templates for program-defined types requires their specialization, otherwise the program is ill-formed.

6. References

The POSIX version of math.h is described at <http://pubs.opengroup.org/onlinepubs/9699919799/basedefs/math.h.html>.

The OpenCL mathematical constants are defined in a file `opengl_math_constants`, see https://raw.githubusercontent.com/KhronosGroup/libclcxx/master/include/opengl_math_constants.

The GNU math extensions: https://gcc.gnu.org/onlinedocs/gcc-6.1.0/libstdc++/api/a01120_source.html

A list of Boost math constants is at http://www.boost.org/doc/libs/release/libs/math/doc/html/math_toolkit/constants.html

7. Acknowledgments

The authors would like to thank Edward Smith-Rowland for his review of the draft proposal, Vishal Oza, Daniel Krügler and Matthew Woehlke for their participation in the related thread at the `std-proposals` user group, Walter E. Brown for volunteering to present the proposal and helpful comments, Richard Smith for his suggestion of the new `<math>` header and participants of discussions at LEWG, SG6 and LWG mailing lists for their valuable feedback.